Finding Our Inner Voice

[Customer dedication message]

This was Alexandra's favorite park in all of Grass Valley.
Swings squeaked. Sneakers thumped. Kids laughed and called, "Again, again!"
Alexandra ran in, ready to play.

Swings. Tunnels. Sand. A climbing wall like a mountain.

Alexandra looked left, then right. "What should I try first?"

Then came a whoosh from way up high.

It was the tall slide.

Kids climbed up. Kids sat down. Kids whooshed all the way to the bottom.

"Again, again!" they shouted.

Alexandra looked up.

The slide looked fun. It also looked very, very tall.

Alexandra climbed to the top.
The slide looked even longer from here.
"Your turn!" "Go!" "It's fun!"
Alexandra's tummy flipped. The top felt small. The slide felt big.
Alexandra did not know what to do.

That night, Alexandra sat quietly on the bed. The slide was far away. The big feeling was still there.

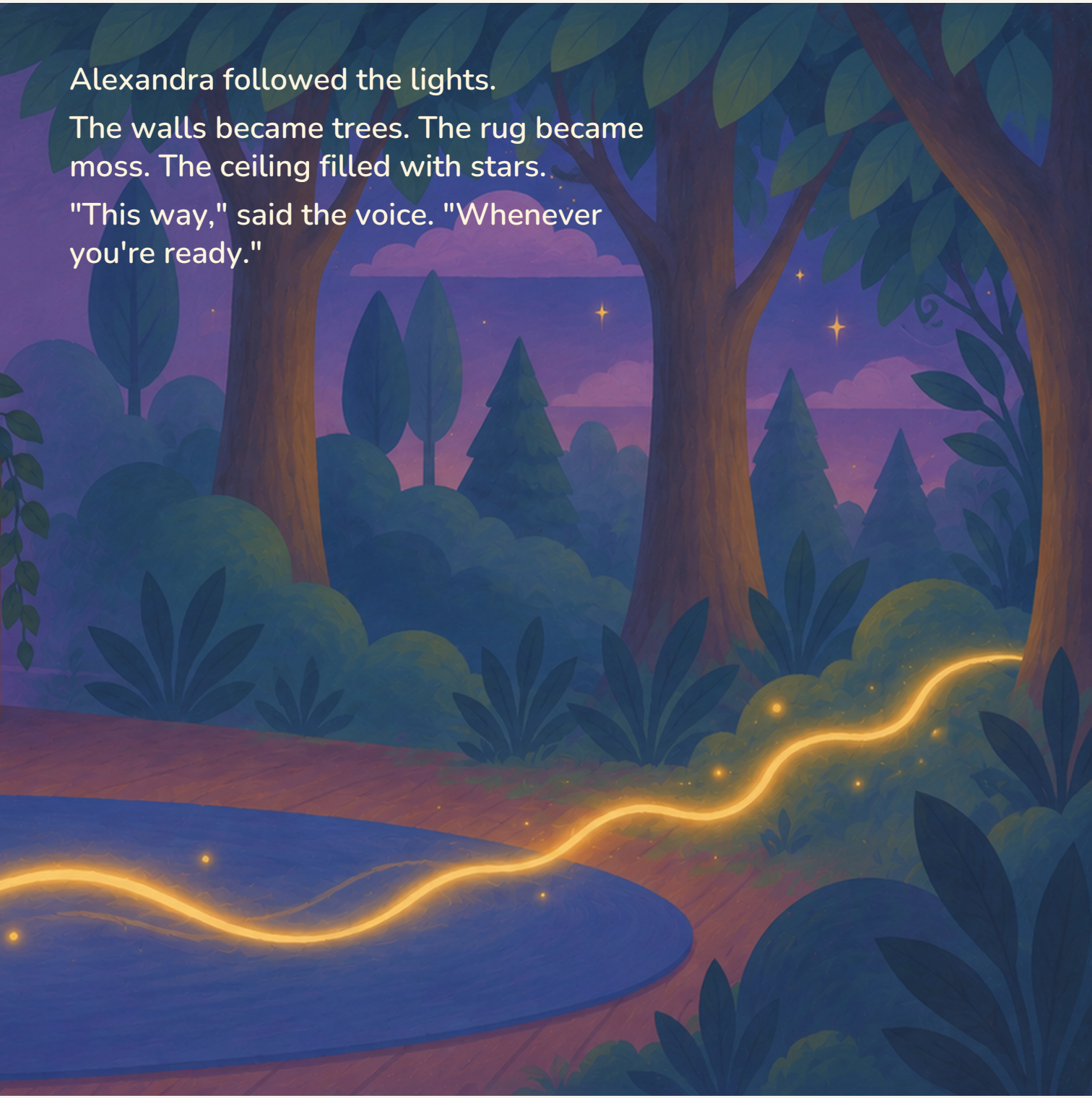
"Your turn!" "Go!" "It's fun!"

Alexandra took a deep breath. The room grew quiet.

"That was scary," said a tiny voice. Alexandra nodded. "Yes."

"Oh! You can hear me now."

"Who said that?" asked Alexandra.
A light blinked beside the bed. Then another. Then another.
The lights made a path across the floor. "Let's look together," said the tiny voice.


Alexandra followed the lights.
The walls became trees. The rug became moss. The ceiling filled with stars.
"This way," said the voice. "Whenever you're ready."

On the quiet path lay a clue: a feather.
Alexandra looked left. Then right.
"Where are you?" called Alexandra.

Something rustled in a bush.
"Are you hiding?" asked Alexandra.
The bush rustled again.
Then it sneezed.
"Achoo!"
Bushes do not usually sneeze.

Before Alexandra could peek, voices called from every direction.

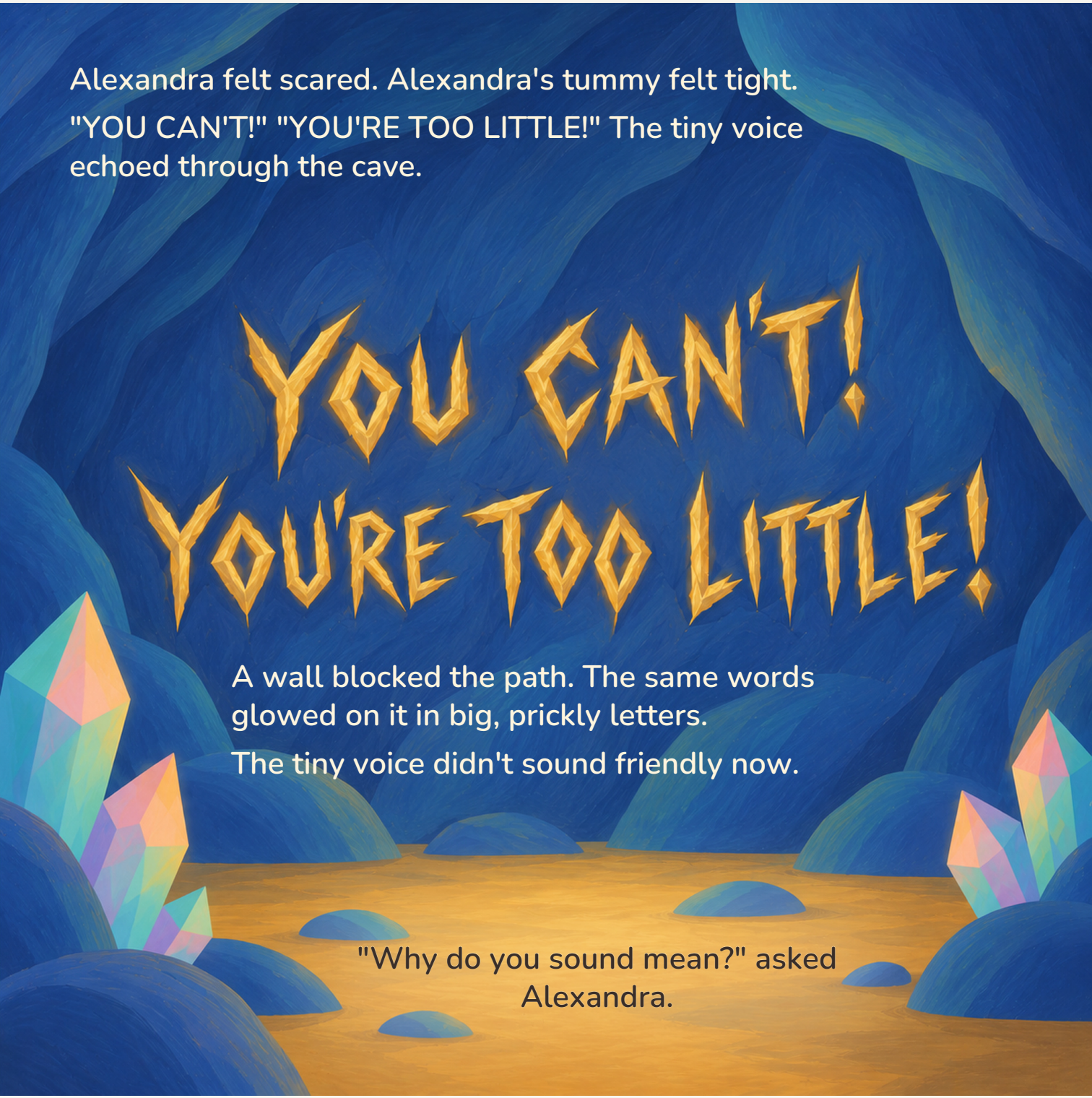
"This way!" blinked a star. "No, this way!" puffed the wind. "Hop!" said a mushroom. "Skip!" said a stone.

A sign spun around. "HURRY!"

"Too many voices make it hard to hear your own," said the tiny voice.
Alexandra stopped. One slow breath.
Alexandra listened for the small, true voice inside.
"Listen close. I'm still here."
And there it was: a quiet path.

The path split in two.
One way was smooth and shiny. It looked easy. The other was plain and steep.
Alexandra looked at the shiny path. It was pretty. But something inside felt tight.
A deep breath. "Not that way," whispered the tiny voice.

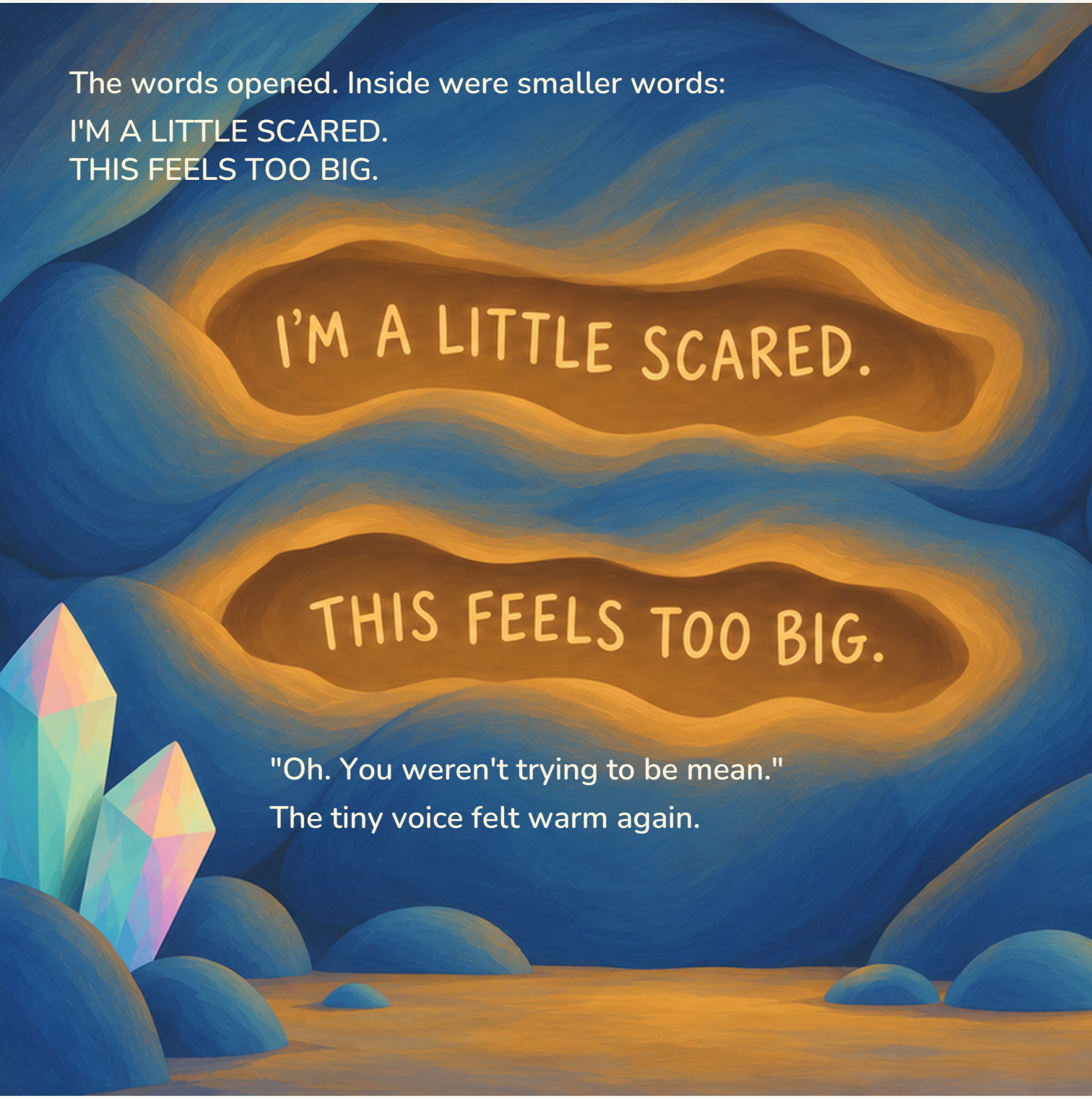
Alexandra chose the steep path.
Up, and up, and up.
At the top, a cave glittered. Alexandra stepped closer.


Alexandra felt scared. Alexandra's tummy felt tight.
"YOU CAN'T!" "YOU'RE TOO LITTLE!" The tiny voice echoed through the cave.
YOU CAN'T!
YOU'RE TOO LITTLE!
A wall blocked the path. The same words glowed on it in big, prickly letters.
The tiny voice didn't sound friendly now.
"Why do you sound mean?" asked Alexandra.

The voice was quiet.
Alexandra remembered. One deep breath. Then another.
The cave grew quieter. The prickly words wiggled. Then softened.

The words opened. Inside were smaller words:

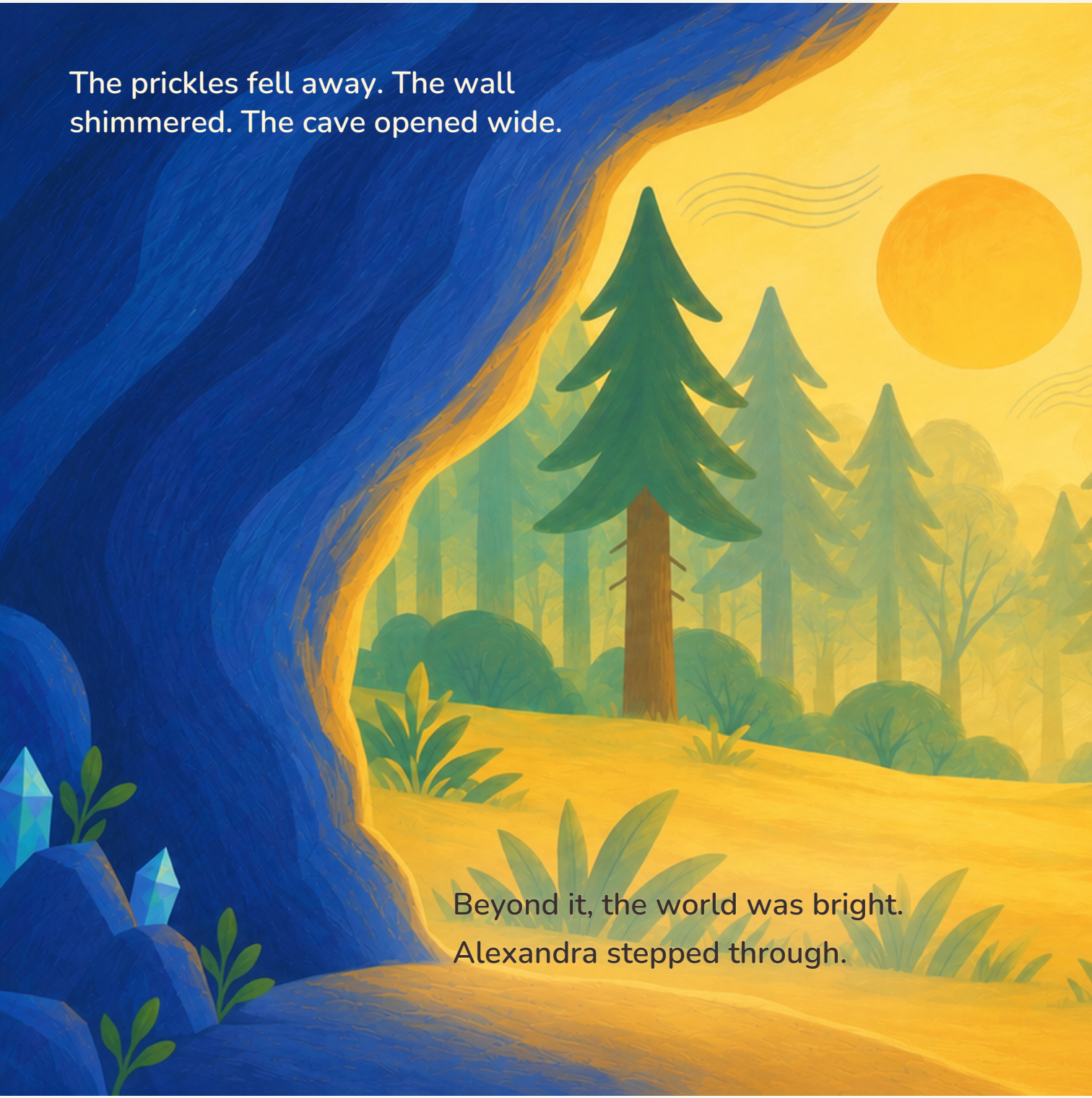
I'M A LITTLE SCARED.
THIS FEELS TOO BIG.



"Oh. You weren't trying to be mean."

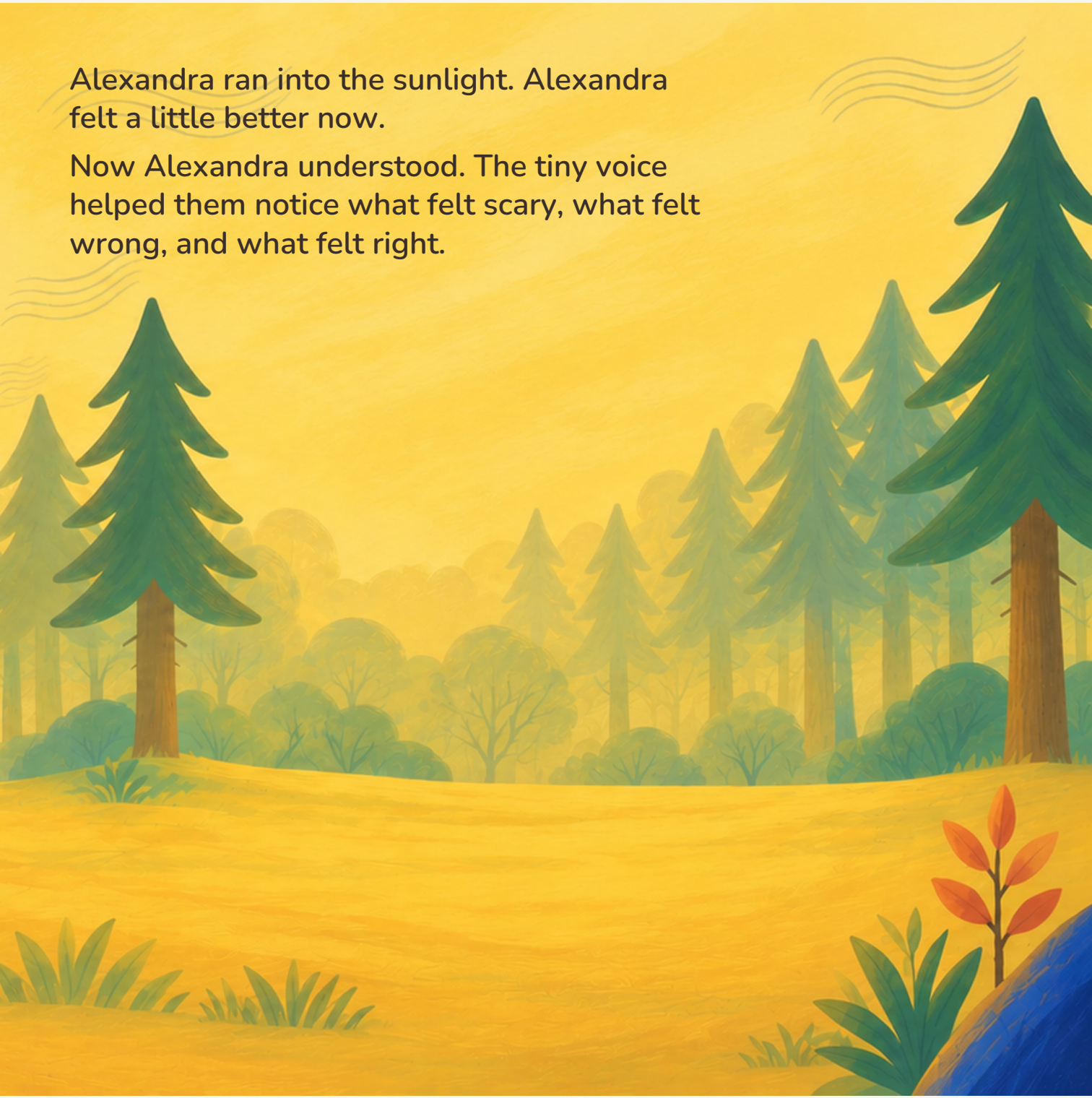
The tiny voice felt warm again.

"Sometimes big feelings come out sharp," said the voice.
"But if you listen close, you can hear what they are really trying to say."


The prickles fell away. The wall shimmered. The cave opened wide.
Beyond it, the world was bright.
Alexandra stepped through.

Alexandra ran into the sunlight. Alexandra felt a little better now.

Now Alexandra understood. The tiny voice helped them notice what felt scary, what felt wrong, and what felt right.



"I want to see you," said Alexandra.
A trail of feathers glowed ahead. The forest grew warmer and quieter.
"Where are you?"
"Listen close," said the tiny voice.
"That quiet is your heart."

In a warm, magical clearing, Owl appeared.

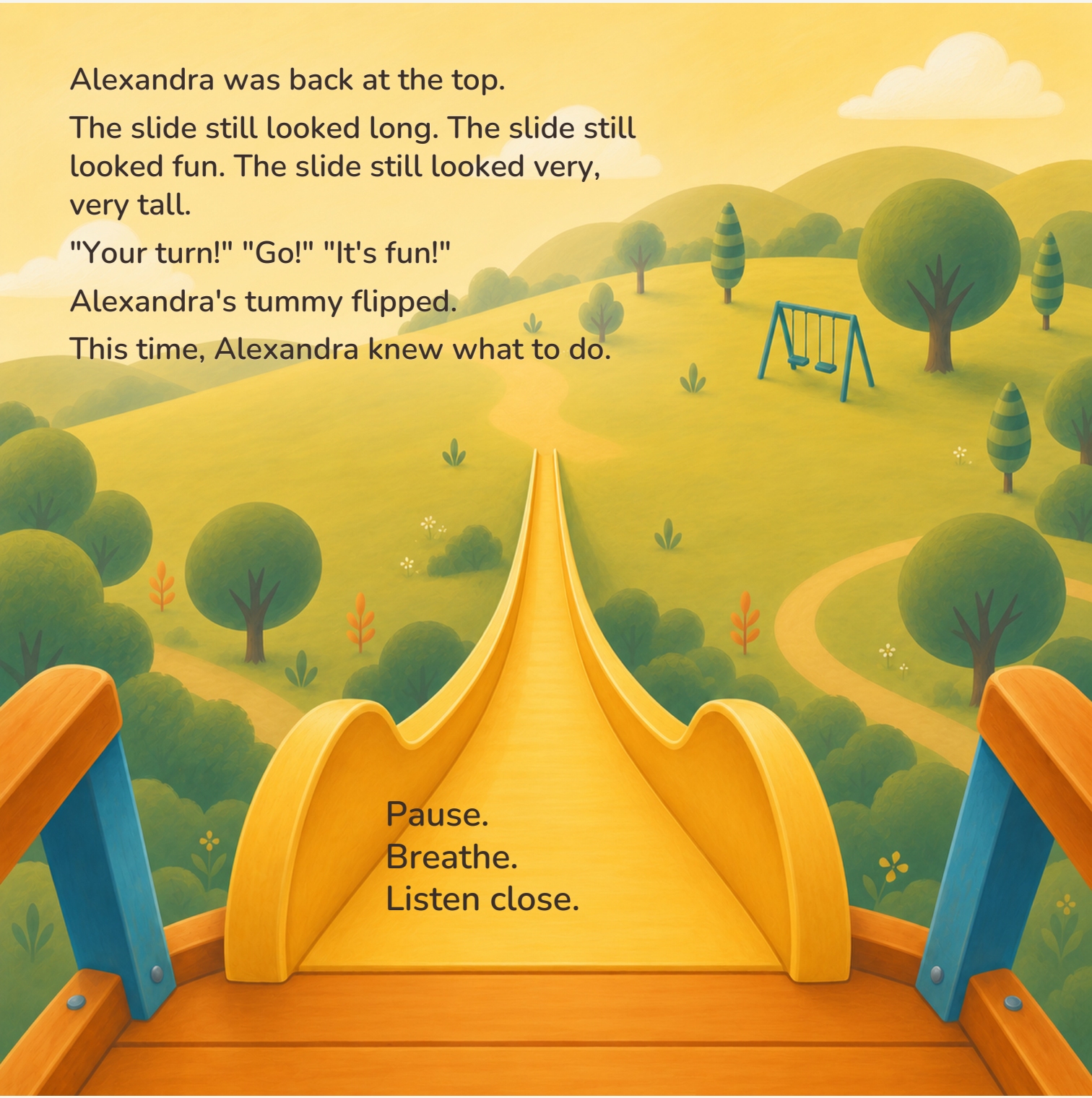
Alexandra gasped. "It was you?"

Owl smiled.

"I am your quiet voice," said Owl, "in a shape you can see."

The warm quiet was inside Alexandra, too.

Alexandra and Owl flew through the stars.
The magical forest grew small below. Ahead was the park, the ladder, and the very, very tall slide.
Owl stayed close. So did the quiet voice.


Alexandra was back at the top.
The slide still looked long. The slide still looked fun. The slide still looked very, very tall.
"Your turn!" "Go!" "It's fun!"
Alexandra's tummy flipped.
This time, Alexandra knew what to do.
Pause.
Breathe.
Listen close.

The quiet voice was there.

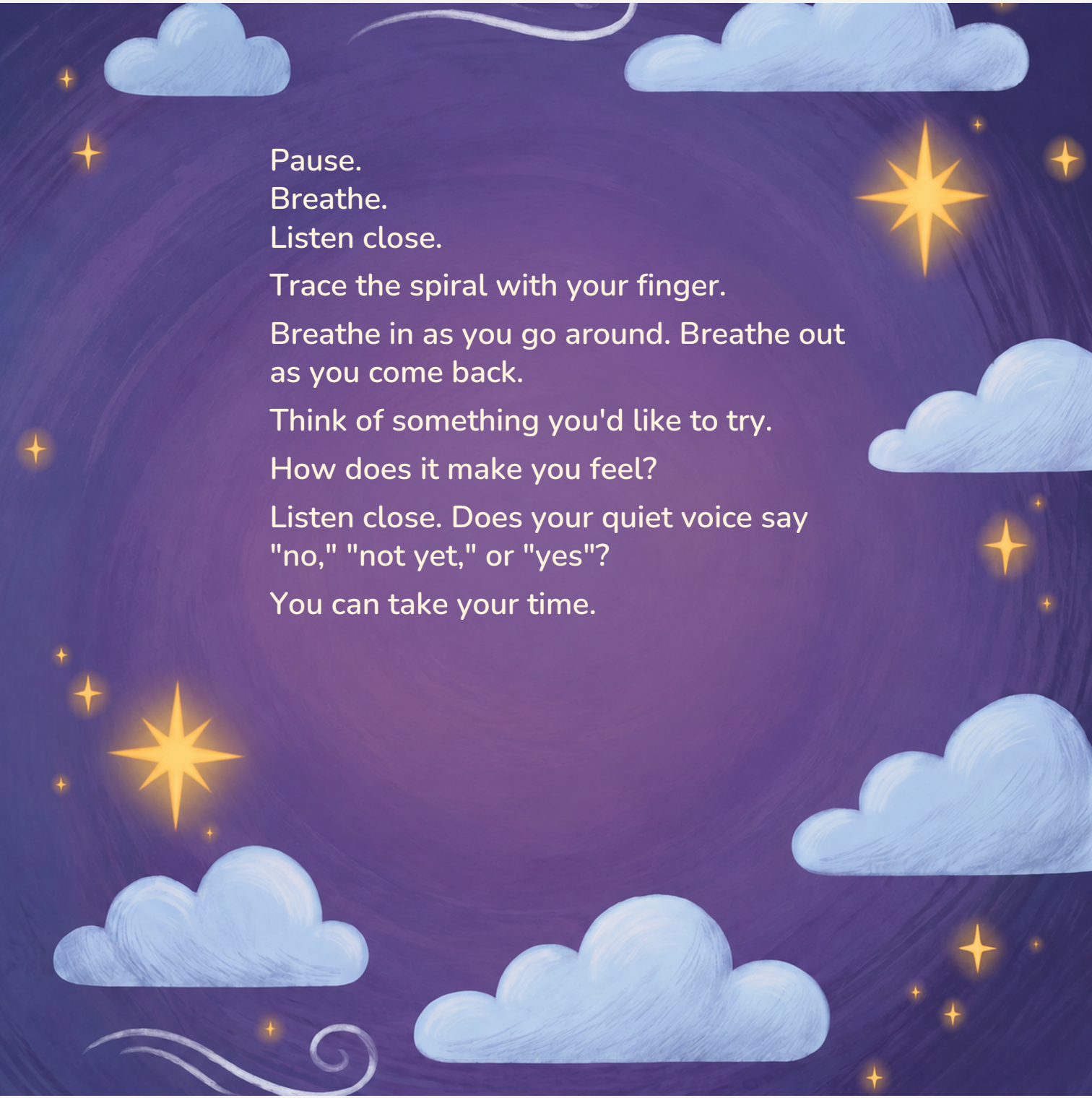
Small and warm.

"Not yet," it said. "Almost."

Alexandra looked at the child waiting behind them.

"You go first," said Alexandra. "I'm almost ready."

And this time, Alexandra smiled.


Pause.
Breathe.
Listen close.
Trace the spiral with your finger.
Breathe in as you go around. Breathe out as you come back.
Think of something you'd like to try.
How does it make you feel?
Listen close. Does your quiet voice say "no," "not yet," or "yes"?
You can take your time.

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For grown-ups

Ask your child: "Was there a time today when you felt ready, or when you wanted to wait?"

Give them time to answer.